

AHMEDABAD | Trial on Hold



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THE SUPREME COURT HAS GRANTED A STAY ON THE TRIAL OF 64 IM MEMBERS IN A GUJARAT COURT.

The Supreme Court last week stayed the trial of 64 Indian Mujahideen (IM) members allegedly involved in a series of terror attacks in the country. The accused had pleaded that they would not get a fair trial in Gujarat and that they were being ill-treated in jail. They sought transfer of their trial outside Gujarat. The stay, just three days before their trial was to begin, may delay and possibly derail the trial. Among the undertrials are the main accused in blasts that hit India from 2005 onwards, including those in Ahmedabad, Delhi, Jaipur and Lucknow. Among the accused are M. Peerbhoy from Pune—charged for sending e-mails about the blasts—and others from Azamgarh, including Arif Badr, alleged to have made timers for the 2008 blasts. The three major exercises in the case—investigation, arrests and the chargesheet—remain unchallenged.

by Uday Mahurkar

LUCKNOW | Khaki Terror

By lynching two youths in its custody in Allahabad on February 15, the Uttar Pradesh Police has kept up its dubious record of brutal high-handedness. After a mob attacked constable Kamlesh Kumar Pandey over a petty dispute in Allahabad, infuriated policemen caught Sanjay and Ashok Nishad and tortured them to death in their custody. The killings have exposed the force's brutality and its insensitivity towards the public.

by Subhash Mishra

TWO PUNJAB BUREAUCRATS ARE AT EACH OTHER'S THROATS OVER CORRUPTION CHARGES

CHANDIGARH | Friends Turn Foes

Not long ago, Punjab Industries Minister Manoranjan Kalia was famously flanked by two of his most "trusted" bureaucrats: industries director Vijay Kumar Janjua and his immediate boss, Principal Secretary S.S. Channy. The two officials are now at loggerheads in public. It all started when the Vigilance Bureau arrested Janjua for allegedly accepting Rs 2 lakh as a bribe from a Ludhiana industrialist in return for allotment of a vacant plot. Janjua, now suspended, says that he was framed at "jealous" Channy's behest as the latter wanted his ouster. He has also lashed out at the raiding sleuths, saying that they acted out of their jurisdiction. The officer has lodged his complaint with the Chandigarh police as well. A shaken Channy retaliated, saying had he been inimical towards Janjua he wouldn't have let him off earlier when he was asked to probe corruption charges against him by the chief secretary. He simply sought Janjua's comments on the charges but the latter just chose to ignore it.

by Arvind Chhabra

